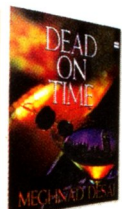


LONDON Underground

An airport thriller by a noted economist borrows its plot from British tabloid fodder

| By Dilip Bobb |



DEAD ON TIME
by MEGHNAD DESAI
HarperCollins
Price: Rs 399
Pages: 238

Going by stereotypes, are economists dry, humourless, scholarly types, immersed in the study of issues such as the Impact of Globalisation on the Lesser Hebrides? Good Lord no! Not this one, anyway. Lord Meghnad Desai, eminent economist, Professor Emeritus at the London School of Economics where he taught for 40 years, and long-time Labour Peer, has a history of challenging convention. He married his second wife in 2004, when he was 64 and she was 47. They met while she was working in publishing, editing his biography of yesteryear Bollywood star Dilip Kumar. Now, he defies typecasting once again with his latest book and his first novel. *Dead on Time* is what the publishing trade calls an 'airport' novel—light, racy fiction with enough scandal, action, crime and sex to keep weary travellers awake while awaiting their flight.

For a proclaimed leftist who has written books with titles such as *Marxian Economic Theory*, it's a dramatic new avatar, one that has been clearly conditioned by decades of reading Britain's lurid tabloids. In fact, the novel could easily have been the outcome of a year's subscription to the *Sun* or *News of the World* since the plot revolves around traditional tabloid fodder; political scandals, sex and football. All Desai has done is change the names and tweak the situations to blur the line between fact and fiction. There's a young, charismatic prime minister with an ambitious wife who deliberately ignores her sex-addicted husband's Monica Lewinsky

moments, a megalomaniac media tycoon, gay MPs, scheming political rivals, an assassination conspiracy, a high-stakes football match, back-room deals in Whitehall, parliamentary rebellions and diplomatic crises.

As a member of the House of Lords for many years, Desai is enough of an insider to bring an aura of authenticity to the proceedings. Whitehall's inner corridors, the placement of statues and rooms in Parliament House, offices in Downing Street are all described in accurate detail. After all, Desai has spent almost two decades as a member of the House of Lords. Where he falters is in trying to include every tabloid editor's dream sequence in just a single day. British politics has had more than its fair share of scandals, and Desai makes liberal, if not excessive, use of fictionalised history. The other drawback is that

it is written by a man who is a junkie on British politics and anyone who is not will find the book difficult to negotiate. Westminster is not the White House. Indeed, so frenetic is the pace and plot, so diverse the cast of characters and so frequent the sex and scandal, that it gets tough keeping up with who's doing what and to whom.

Desai is honest enough to admit that he wasn't writing a Booker Prize winning novel. What we have is a Bonker's Prize novel, but one that lives up to its literary genre. Airport novels are for time-pass and this fits that requirement except that Desai introduces enough twists and turns to give a pretzel, or a *jalebi*, an inferiority complex. If your flight is delayed, this could be just the ticket. If it's dead on time and you are no fan of British politics, head straight for the departure gates. ■



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